End of Google Buzz
Google has announced the closure of Google Buzz to welcome Google+
http://bit.ly/qqofSx

ASUS Swap
ASUS has started a “swap“ service for its UAE customers where they can swap defective parts

- the Extreme7. The heatsinks are quite sturdy and it houses a POST debug LED as well as power/reset switches for overclockers. However, it has fewer SATA ports, USB 3.0 ports and one less LAN port as compared to the Extreme7. Still, for its pricing, the board is quite feature-rich. Build quality is great, it uses solid state caps and has a UEFI BIOS. It lacks a USB 3.0 header, but no other board in this category has it either. One interesting aspect is that it has a provision for coolers of both, the Socket LGA 1155 as well as the LGA 775, there’s a very thin gap between them, be extra careful while installing a high-end cooler.

Winner: ASRock proved its mettle yet again, when it bagged the Best Buy award for ASRock Z68 Extreme3 Gen3.

A75 boards

AMD introduced its Fusion desktop APU in the form of Llano and along with it, the A75 chipset-based motherboards. The A75 chipset supports 10 USB 2.0 ports, 4 USB 3.0 ports, 2 USB 1.1 ports (we think it’s a waste) and 4 PCIe Gen 2 slots among other things. The boards based on this chipset are priced economically as the APU that we used (A8-3850) is targetted at mainstream users. The quad core Llano APU houses the AMD HD 6550D GPU, which is based on the Redwood architecture and has 400 stream processing units.

ASRock A75 Extreme6

itive as far as the A75 boards is concerned, as performance is a function of the components being used. Culling the best motherboards for the price is quite a task

Let’s start off with ASUS as it sent the maximum number of boards, namely: F1A75-M LE, F1A75M, F1 A75M Pro and F1A75 V Pro. As is obvious from the naming convention, the LE is a lower-end board, whereas the Pro boards are high-end. All the boards except the F1A75-V Pro have micro ATX form factor. Apart from that, the V Pro has an additional SATA 6 Gbps port, more PCI and PCIe x1 slots, an eSATA port and a DisplayPort on the back IO panel and a better heatsink with connecting heat-pipe. The F1A75 M LE and F1A75 M both have only two USB 3.0 ports. The LE board has only two DIMM RAM slots and lacks a HDMI port. Its SATA ports point upwards not sideways—a big turn off for wire management.

The F1A75-V Pro has better heatsinks than other ASUS boards; the F1A75M, F1A75M LE don’t have heatsink over the VRMs.

Biostar TA75A+ is a feature -rich board but we would have liked to see some more USB 3.0 ports and a better heat-sink design for the south bridge. Looking at the layout, one gets the feel that this board could have been a micro ATX one as 2 PCI and 2 PCIe x1 slots seem a lot. The POST debug LED is a great addition for overclocking, but is not as exhaustive or as good looking as the MSI or ASUS BIOS. The heatsink quality is quite bad. The BIO Remote is a nice feature to show off to your friends. It allows you to control your system, play back media files and even overclock over the air using the Bio remote app on your iPhone or Android device. Thankfully all the SATA ports point outwards.

The ECS A75F-M, is an interesting board especially considering its pricing. The board comes in the microATX form factor and has bare minimum features. Cost cutting on the board is evident - absence of a dedicated heat sink around the VRMs, use of electrolytic capacitors, upward facing SATA ports, and two USB 3.0 drives. It sports a UEFI BIOS with both the EZ and Advanced mode. The USB 3.0 charger helps in charging peripheral devices in as many as five states: working, standby, suspend to RAM, etc.

The MSI A75MA-G55, is an impressive board having a military class certification. So, expect rock-solid build quality on the board. You get the option to overclock the processor as well as the integrated graphics in an incremental manner. Of the six SATA ports on board, two of them point upward, which can be problematic if you want to install a graphics card in the second slot.

Gigabyte had three boards competing in this category: A75M-D2H, A75M-UD2H and A75-D3H. The A75M-D2H is an entry-level board with only two RAM slots and two USB 3.0 ports. The UD2H has four DIMM slots but a much more populated back IO panel, which includes an eSATA port as well as a FireWire port. All the display ports such as HDMI, DVI, VGA and DP are present on the UD2H. Both, the D2H and UD2H are micro ATX form factor boards. The A75-D3H is an ATX form factor board having all four USB 3.0 ports on the back IO panel and an option to add two more with the USB 3.0 header. Three PCI slots do seem like a lot and the second PCIe x16 slot runs at x4 speed. A heatsink around the VRM region is absent and there is one SATA port pointing upwards. All the Gigabyte boards feature the proprietary DualBIOS chips which allows you to maintain a backup of the last stable BIOS on one chip, while you tweak the active BIOS. Gigabyte BIOS is still the old generation one and it’s a real pity to have such good boards anf not have them running the latest UEFI BIOS.

ASRock sent us two boards, theA75 Extreme 6 and A75 Pro4-M. The former is it’s flagship A75 board and the latter is a mid-range board. The Extreme 6 comes with good features including eight SATA 3 ports, POST debug LED, start/reset buttons and three PCIe slots among other things. Build quality is very sturdy. The Pro4-M is the lower-end model with no USB 3.0 header, two less USB 3.0 ports and SATA ports pointing upwards (which we know by now is not desirable). Both these boards support the UEFI BIOS.

Winner: In case of the A75 boards the pricing was very close, so we decided to just award one board. ASRock A75 Extreme 6 won the Best Buy award. Its features were neck-to-neck with the ASUS F1A75 V Pro, but the Extreme 6 had better build quality, dedicated power/reset buttons and a slightly better board layout. Also, features such as a dedicated power/reset button and a POST debug LED gave the Extreme 6 a push in the right direction.

If you don’t intend to spend that much, you can go for the ECS A75F-M. The other good board is the Gigabyte A75M-UD2H.